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Title of the article: *Gun Shops as Local Institutions: Federal Firearms Licensees, Social Disorganization, and Neighborhood Violent Crime*

The content extracted is as follows:

Such research has focused primarily on institutions that provide ample suitable targets and crime victims, such as bars, pawn shops, and payday lenders (e.g., Roncek and Maier 1991; Kubrin and Hipp 2014).

We explore a different institution that likely affects crime rates: the gun shop.¹ Routine activities theory suggests that by being a business with desirable goods, gun shops could directly affect crime by providing targets and victims.

Social disorganization theory suggests that gun shops could also have a significant indirect effect on neighborhood crime by negatively influencing perceptions of the neighborhood, sending signals of disorganization that discourage residents from engaging in social control efforts.

Specifically, because gun dealers can be viewed as undesirable businesses that are frequently the target of NIMBY (Not in My Backyard) efforts, the presence of gun shops could suggest that residents do not care enough about the neighborhood to block the shop's establishment, or that residents were unable to do so.

This could discourage future social control efforts, as such efforts may seem futile or unappreciated. Additionally, gun shops signal that guns are present in a neighborhood, which could raise fear among those uncomfortable around firearms, thus discouraging them from intervening when disorder occurs.

Subsequently, we would expect to find higher crime rates in neighborhoods with gun shops, as the associated fear and negative perceptions might keep residents from engaging in social control efforts, while the shops themselves might attract crime by providing suitable targets.

It is not that the guns sold generate crime, but that the shops trigger processes that lead to more crime.

To test the relationship between gun shops and crime, we employ multilevel Poisson models and three unique datasets: the National Neighborhood Crime Study (NNCS), the Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco, Firearms, and Explosives Federal Firearms Licensees Database (FFLD), and the National Establishment Time-Series Longitudinal Business Database (NETS) to examine the effects of gun shop presence on neighborhood crime rates.

These datasets allow us to test whether gun shops are associated with elevated crime rates at the neighborhood level, while also accounting for neighborhood and gun shop characteristics.

Most empirical research on the relationship between gun shops and violent crime has examined larger geographic units, such as cities and counties (Wiebe et al. 2009), which are too big to accurately measure neighborhood effects, or gun shows (Duggan, Hjalmarsson, and Jacob 2010), which are a short-term phenomenon unlikely to have lasting effects.

Additionally, this research expands our understanding of the role of local institutions on crime outcomes, not only by examining a different institution: gun shops but also by examining the relationship nationwide.

Firearms Dealers and Crime

As businesses, routine activities theory would predict that gun shops would be associated with elevated crime rates because they provide suitable targets and desirable goods.

Individuals are more likely to carry guns when they feel law enforcement and the criminal justice system are insufficient to protect them from crime (McDowall and Loftin 1983; Young, McDowall, and Loftin 1987).

Seeing a gun shop in the neighborhood signals that guns are present here, which could increase fear among those who feel less safe when guns are prevalent.

Finally, if many urban residents see gun shops as undesirable, seeing a gun shop in a neighborhood could send the signal that no one in the neighborhood cared enough to stop (or was incapable of stopping) the gun shop from locating there.

Thus, gun dealers likely lead to increased crime in an area directly, through mechanisms predicted by routine activities theory providing suitable targets and indirectly, through disruptions to social control efforts, as predicted by social disorganization theory.

Likewise, pawn shops, which have been associated with increases in crime rates (Kubrin and Hipp 2014), are also qualitatively different than dealers that focus solely on guns.

We account for these differences in our analysis, but think that the processes we discuss play a role in the gun shop crime relationship to some degree, regardless of shop type.

Expectations

Following our argument that gun shops in urban areas provide suitable targets for crime and can signal disorder in a way that affects social control efforts we have three hypotheses.

First, we expect that higher gun shop prevalence will be associated with higher crime rates in urban neighborhoods.

Second, we expect that higher gun shop prevalence in urban areas will be associated with higher crime rates regardless of gun shop type.

Data and Methods

To examine the association between gun shops and crime, we rely on data from the National Neighborhood Crime Study (NNCS), the Federal Firearms Licensees Database (FFLD), and the National Establishment Time-Series Longitudinal Business Database (NETS).

Finally, because gun shops are often located near other institutions that could lead to increased crime rates, such as other commercial establishments, we control for the number of total retail establishments per 10,000 residents in each tract.

Findings

As discussed earlier, most neighborhoods in large US cities do not have gun shops.

However, in neighborhoods with at least one gun shop, there are 5.7 FFLs per 10,000 residents, on average.

Most gun shops (1.8 per 10,000) in the sample are traditional firearms dealers, but there is variation in the number of dealers, pawn shops, and big box stores across US neighborhoods.

Although neighborhoods with FFLs are located in metro areas with relatively more FFLs, tracts without FFLs remain located in metro areas with at least 2.5 shops per 10,000 residents.

Specifically, while the higher rates of homicide and robbery in neighborhoods without FFLs suggest that gun dealers are not opening stores in high-crime neighborhoods, the true relationship between FFLs and local crime rates may be concealed by structural factors.

Table 3 presents the coefficients and standard errors for models similar to those found in table 2, but adds the concentrations of traditional firearms dealers, pawn shops, and big box retailers as predictor variables.⁵ Looking first at model 1, the association between FFLs and violent crime rates varies slightly across store type.

Unlike traditional dealers and pawn shops, the relationship between the presence of big box stores that sell firearms and rates of neighborhood homicide is negative, although this relationship is only marginally significant.

For neighborhood homicide rates, the effects of traditional dealers and pawn shops are similar ($\chi^2 = .094$, $p > .10$), and both types of stores have significantly stronger effects than the concentration of big box retailers ($\chi^2 = 22.610$, $p < .05$, and $\chi^2 = 6.077$, $p < .05$, respectively).

Notably, the relationship between the concentration of pawn shops with FFLs and violence is less pronounced in more disadvantaged neighborhoods than in less disadvantaged neighborhoods.

At one standard deviation below mean neighborhood disadvantage, tracts with twice as many pawn shops per 10,000 residents have 24.84 percent $[(e^{.132 + (.1^* .090)} - 1) * 100]$ higher homicide rates and 29.94 $[(e^{.190 + (.1^* .072)} - 1) * 100]$ higher robbery rates than other tracts.

At one standard deviation above mean neighborhood disadvantage, a similar difference in the concentration of pawn shops is associated with just 4.38 percent $[(e^{.132+(1 \cdot .090)} - 1) \cdot 100]$ higher homicide rates and 12.57 $[(e^{.190+(1 \cdot .072)} - 1) \cdot 100]$ higher robbery rates than other tracts.

To summarize, the presence of gun shops in a neighborhood is associated with higher rates of homicide and robbery.

Unstable neighborhoods with one gun shop per 10,000 residents have, on average, 1.33 homicides per 10,000 residents.

In general, the patterns revealed by the models suggest that the presence of gun shops is associated with higher rates of homicide and robbery in neighborhoods.

Although urban residents remain more skeptical of gun rights than suburban or rural residents (Blocher 2013), temporal shifts in opinions on firearms could change the relationship between gun shops and crime, especially given the role of perceptions in our theory.

Specifically, the relationship between gun shops and violent crime could operate in the opposite direction from what we hypothesize.

Seeking selfprotection, residents of high-crime neighborhoods may demand or provide a market for gun dealers.

Indeed, descriptive results presented in table 1 suggest that crime rates are actually higher in neighborhoods without gun shops.

Discussion and Conclusion

Our research adds to this discussion by considering federally licensed gun shops as neighborhood institutions.

We argue that along with providing opportunities for crime, gun shops could signal disorder and indirectly contribute to crime rates.

Results from these models suggest that there is a relationship between gun shop presence and local crime rates in urban areas.

Specifically, our results indicate that homicide and robbery rates increase as the number of gun shops in a neighborhood increases (weighted by the tract population).

The relationship between gun shops and crime appears to be entirely local.

The effect of metropolitan-level gun shop presence on local crime rates is insignificant.

We argue that gun shops foster crime directly by providing opportunities for crime and indirectly most likely by changing perceptions of the neighborhood and instilling fear in residents that weakens social control efforts.

Likewise, one would not expect the effect of changed perceptions to spread far beyond the shop; a far-ung dealer should not change people's perceptions of the local neighborhood.

If crime results from increased gun presence, there should be higher crime rates in tracts in cities with more gun shops.

The fact that we did not find an association between local crime and metropolitan dealers suggests that crime is not resulting from guns themselves, but from a process specific to the shop, like the direct and indirect effects proposed above.

Adding gun shops to these neighborhoods could interrupt social control efforts and potentially trigger decline.

It is plausible that selectively issuing local licenses to gun shops could help stymie decline and increases in crime in these fragile neighborhoods.

Leaving gun shop interventions to the neighborhood risks perpetuating inequality that already stratifies neighborhoods, making it more likely that already-organized (and thus likely lower-crime) neighborhoods will be successful, while disorganized neighborhoods will fail and become even more disorganized. So, regardless of the policy strategy pursued, efforts at limiting the effects of gun shop presence on neighborhood crime that come from outside the neighborhood (i.e., government action) are those with the greatest potential effect.